Poof!

By Lynn Nottage

SAMUEL: **(Pgs 523-534)** *(offstage)* WHEN I COUNT TO TEN, I DON' WANT TO SEE YA! I DON' WANT TO HEAR YA! ONE, TWO, THREE, FOUR . . .

LOUREEN: DAMN YOU TO HELL, SAMUEL! *(a bright flash)*

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: **According to the Bexar County Family Justice Center, yearly an estimated 1.3 million women in the US are victims of physical assault by a domestic partner each year. Many cases go unreported because help often doesn't come.*
ACTRESS 2: *And when women fight back, they can be punished. **In 2021 women were responsible for just 10% of homicides. Many cases involved a history of domestic abuse.*
ACTRESS 1: *In this selection, reality is pushed to the extreme. After years of silence, one moment of speaking out . . .*
ACTRESS 2: *"DAMN YOU TO HELL, SAMUEL!"*
ACTRESS 1: *. . . makes Loureen's abusive husband spontaneously combust.*
ACTRESS 2: *What follows is fear, confusion and an almost giddy relief.*
ACTRESS 1: *For many women, escaping abuse isn't simple. But it does raise the question: When survival becomes a crime…*
ACTRESS 2: *What choice is there?*
TOGETHER: *Poof! by Lynn Nottage*

A huge pile of smoking ashes rests in the middle of the kitchen. LOUREEN, a demure housewife in her early thirties, stares down at the ashes incredulously. She bends and lifts a pair of spectacles from the remains. She ever so slowly backs away)

LOUREEN: Samuel? Uh! *(places the spectacles on the kitchen table; looks around)* Don't fool with me now. I'm not in the mood. *(whispers)* Samuel? I didn't mean it really. I'll be good if you come back. . . Come on now, dinner's waiting. *(chuckles, then stops abruptly)* Now stop your foolishness. *(examines the spectacles)* Uh! *(softly)* Don't be cross with me. Sure, I forgot to pick up your shirt for tomorrow. I can wash another, I'll do it right now. Right now! Sam? *(cautiously)* You hear me!*(awaits a response)* Maybe I didn't ever intend to wash your shirt! *(pulls back as though about to receive a blow; a moment)* Uh! *(dials the telephone)* Florence, honey could you come down for a moment. There's been a little accident. *(gets a broom and a*

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dust pan, hesitantly approaches the pile of ashes. Takes a closer look. Grins)

FLORENCE: *(enters in a rush)* HEY!

LOUREEN: *(pointing at the ashes)* Uh! *(struggles to formulate words)* Uh!

FLORENCE: You all right? What happened? *(sniffs the air)* Smells like you burned something? *(stares at the huge pile of ashes)* What the devil is that?

LOUREEN: *(hushed)* Samuel. . . It's Samuel, I think. *(nods her head repeatedly)* It's him. It's him.

FLORENCE: Chile, what's wrong with you? Did he finally drive you out your mind? I knew something was going to happen sooner or later.

LOUREEN: Dial 911, Florence! Dial 911! *(FLORENCE picks up the telephone and quickly dials)* I think I killed him.

FLORENCE: *(hangs up)* What?

LOUREEN: *(whimpers)* I killed him! I killed Samuel! *(wrings her hands)*

FLORENCE: Come again. . . He's dead, dead? *(backs away)* No, stop it, I don't have time for this. I'm going back upstairs, you know how Samuel hates to find me here when he gets home. You're not going to get me this time. *(louder)* Y'all can have your little joke, I'm not part of it! *(a moment -- takes a hard look at LOUREEN; squints)* Did you really do it this time?

LOUREEN: *(hushed)* I don't know how or why it happened, it just did.

FLORENCE: Why are you whispering?

LOUREEN: I don't want to talk too loud something else is liable to disappear.

FLORENCE: Where's his body?

LOUREEN: *(points to the pile of ashes)* There! ...

FLORENCE: You burned him?

LOUREEN: I DON'T KNOW! *(covers her mouth as to muffle her words; hushed)* I think so.

FLORENCE: Either you did or you didn't, what you mean you don't know. We're talking murder Loureen, not oven settings.

LOUREEN: You think I'm playing?

FLORENCE: How many times have I heard you talk about being rid of him. How many times have we sat at this very table and laughed about the many ways we could do it and how many

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times have you done it? None.

LOUREEN: *(lifting the spectacles)* A pair of cheap spectacles, that's all that's left. And you know how much I hate these. You ever seen him without them, no! . . . He counted to four and disappeared. I swear to God!

FLORENCE: Don't bring the Lord into this just yet! Take your time.

LOUREEN: He was . . . standing there.

FLORENCE: And?

LOUREEN: He exploded. Boom! Right in front of me. He was shouting like he does, then he raised up that big crusty hand to hit me, and poof, he was gone . . . I barely got words out and I'm looking down at a pile of ash.

FLORENCE: *(wipes her forehead)* Chile, I'll give you this, you've matched my husband Edgar, the story king. He came in at six Sunday morning, talking about he'd hit someone with his car, and had spent all night trying to outrun the police. I felt sorry for him, forgot all about the fact that it was six in the morning. It turns out he was playing poker with his paycheck no less.

LOUREEN: You think I'm lying.

FLORENCE: I certainly hope so, Loureen. For your sake.

LOUREEN: Samuel always said if I raised my voice something horrible would happen. And it did!

FLORENCE: You've been watching too much television.

LOUREEN: Never seen anything like this on television. Wish I had, then I'd know what to do. . . He's not coming back. Oh no, how could he. It would be a miracle. Two in one day. . . I could be canonized, worse yet he could be. . . All that needs to happen now is for my palms to bleed and I'll be eternally remembered as St. Loureen, the patron of battered wives. Women from across the country will make pilgrimages to me, laying pies and pot roast at my feet and asking the good saint to make their husbands turn to dust. How often does a man like Samuel get damned to hell and go? *(breaks down as though crying, but as FLORENCE consoles her friend, she realizes that LOUREEN is actually laughing hysterically)* I DON'T KNOW WHAT TO DO NEXT! DO I SWEEP HIM UP? DO I CALL THE POLICE? *(deep breath)* I should be mourning, I should be praying, I should be thinking of the burial, but all that keeps popping into my mind is what will I

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wear on television when I share my horrible and wonderful story with a studio audience *(whimpers)* He's made me a killer Florence, and you remember what a gentle child I was. *(whispers)* I'm a killer, I'm a killer, I'm a killer.

FLORENCE: I wouldn't throw that word about too lightly even in jest. Talk like that gets around.

LOUREEN: I'll probably get the death penalty, isn't that what they do with women like me, murderesses.

FLORENCE: Folks have done time for less.

LOUREEN: Thank you, just what I needed to hear!

FLORENCE: What did you expect, that I was going to throw up my arms and congratulate you. Why'd you have to go and lose your mind at this time of day, while I got a pot of rice on the stove and Edgar's about to walk in the door and wonder where his damn food is. *(losing her cool)* And he's going to start in on me about all the nothing I've been doing during the day and why I can't work and then he'll mention how clean you keep your home. And I don't know how I'm going to look him in the eye without . . .

LOUREEN: I'm sorry Florence. Really. It's out of my hands now. *(takes FLORENCE's hand and squeezes it)*

FLORENCE: *(regains her composure)* You swear? You know what will happen if you're lying. *(LOUREEN nods) (FLORENCE examines the pile of ashes, then shakes her head)* Oh sweet, sweet Jesus. He must have done something truly terrible.

LOUREEN: No more than usual. I just couldn't take being hit one more time.

FLORENCE: You've taken a thousand blows from that man. Couldn't you've turned the cheek and waited. I'd have helped you pack. Like we talked about. *(a moment)*

LOUREEN: Uh! ... I could blow on him and he'd disappear across the linoleum. *(snaps her fingers)* Just like that! Should I be feeling remorse or regret or some other "r" word? I'm strangely jubilant, like on prom night. That's the feeling! *(they lock eyes)* Uh!

FLORENCE: Is it ...

LOUREEN: Like a ton of bricks been lifted from my shoulders . . . yeah.

FLORENCE: *(walks to the other side of the room)* You b***! We made a pact. We agreed that

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when things got real bad for both of us we'd . . . you know . . . together. . . Do I have to go back upstairs to that . . . What next?

LOUREEN: I thought you'd tell me! I don't know!

FLORENCE: I don't know! *(walks around the room nervously. LOUREEN wrings her hands and mumbles softly to herself)* Now you got me Loureen, I'm truly at a loss for words.

LOUREEN: Everybody always told me, "keep your place Loureen." My place, the silent spot on the couch with a pleasant smile that warmed the heart. All this time I didn't know why he was so afraid for me to say anything, to speak up. Poof! . . . I've never been by myself, except for them two weeks when he won the office pool and went to Reno with his cousin Mitchell. He wouldn't tell me where he was going until I got that postcard with the cowboy smoking a hundred cigarettes . . . *(FLORENCE nervously picks up SAMUEL's jacket, which is hanging on the back of the chair. She clutches it unconsciously)*

LOUREEN: NO! NO! DON'T WRINKLE THAT, THAT'S HIS FAVORITE JACKET. HE'LL KILL ME. PUT IT BACK! *(FLORENCE returns the jacket to its perch. LOUREEN begins to quiver)* I'm sorry. *(grabs the jacket and wrinkles it up)* There. *(digs into the coat pockets and pulls out his wallet and a movie stub)* Look at that, he said he didn't go to the movies last night. Working late. *(frantically thumbs through his wallet)* Picture of his motorcycle, social security card, driver's license, and look at that from our wedding. *(smiling)* I looked good, didn't I? *(puts the pictures back in the wallet and holds the jacket up to her face)* There were some good things. *(sweeps her hand over the jacket to remove the wrinkles and throws it in the garbage)* DAMN YOU TO HELL, SAMUEL! Those words made him disappear. Allthese years and just words, Florence. That's all they were.

FLORENCE: I'm afraid, I won't ever get those words out. I'll start resenting you, honey. I'm afraid won't anything change for me. Edgar has never done me the way Samuel did you, but he sure did take the better part of my life. *(shakes her head)* I have the children to think of. Right?

LOUREEN: You can think up a hundred things before . . .

FLORENCE: *(with an idea)* Come upstairs with me . . . We'll wait together for Edgar and then you can spit out your words and . . .

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LOUREEN: I can't do that.

FLORENCE: Ye,s you can! Come on now. *(LOUREEN shakes her head)* Well I guess my mornings are not going to be any different. *(bitterly)* But you got a broom and a dustpan, you don't need anything more than that . . . He was a bastard and nobody will care that he's gone.

LOUREEN: Phone's gonna start ringing soon, people are gonna start asking soon, and they'll care. Maybe I should mail him to his mother. I owe her that. I feel bad for her, she didn't understand how it was . . . He was always threatening not to come back.

FLORENCE: I heard him.

LOUREEN: It would've been me eventually.

FLORENCE: Yes.

LOUREEN: I should call the police, or someone.

FLORENCE: Why? What are you gonna tell them? About all those times they refused to help, about all those nights you slept in my bed 'cause you were afraid to stay down here. About the time he nearly took out your eye 'cause you flipped the television channel.

LOUREEN: I can't just throw him away and pretend like it didn't happen. Can I? *(FLORENCE nods)* Goodbye to the fatty meats and the salty food. Goodbye to the bourbon and the bologna sandwiches. Goodbye to the smell of his feet, his breath, and his bowel movements . . . *(a moment; closes her eyes as though reliving a horrible memory, she shudders and walks over to the pile of ashes)* Samuel? . . . just checking.

FLORENCE: Goodbye Samuel. *(both smile)*

LOUREEN: Chicken's warming in the oven, you're welcome to stay.

FLORENCE: Chile, I got a pot of rice on the stove. Kids are probably acting out . . . snd Edgar, well . . . Listen, I'll stop in tomorrow. *(they hug for a long moment. FLORENCE exits. LOUREEN stands over the ashes for a few moments contemplating what to do. She finally decides to sweep them under the carpet)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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Introduction Statistics:

**Bexar County Family Justice Center: https://bcfjc.org/184/Domestic-Violence-Facts?itemDetail=31fafa1d-c7cb-4914-9186-f6b71fe00de6&contentId=1ed12fc1-7cf3-4c04-bbf9-96eaac26777e*

*** Why Women Kill by Sarah Johnson, 28 Nov 2005*
https://www.theguardian.com/global-development/2025/nov/28/why-women-kill-prison-domestic-violence-abuse?utm_source=chatgpt.com

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